

Medical Emoji

A one-page brief for the American Medical Informatics Association

Prepared for the AMIA Board

medicalemoji.org

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THE ASK: ONE THING

A single AMIA letter of support to the Unicode Consortium, modeled on the one ACEP wrote, affirming the value of a standardized set of medical emoji. It commits AMIA to nothing else; we handle the Unicode proposals, the usage evidence, and the artwork. A turnkey draft letter is attached.

The 6 symbols in our **August 2026** Unicode submission



Kidney

Chronic kidney disease
~10% of adults



Liver

~2M deaths/yr; NAFLD
~25% of US adults



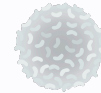
Stomach

GI disease, GERD, ulcers



Spine

Low back pain: #1 cause
of disability



White blood cell

Infection, immunity,
sepsis



EKG

Cardiovascular disease,
#1 killer

We have done this before



In 2020 our physician team added the first anatomically accurate heart and lungs to the Unicode Standard. They now render on essentially every phone: Apple (iOS 14.2), Google, Samsung, Microsoft. This is the proven next slate, not a concept pitch.

The evidence is published

- JAMA (2021): the clinical case for medical emoji.
- JAMA (2022): an emoji pain scale matched the standard numeric scale.
- JAMA Network Open (2023): the case for a comprehensive set.
- Covered by the Boston Globe & The Verge; STAT (Jan 2026) found emoji rising fast in clinical records.

Organized medicine already backs it

ACEP: whole project AGA ASGE ASN ISN
NKF KDIGO AAKP + a dozen more

What is still missing is the voice of organized informatics. That is AMIA.

Why this is AMIA's lane

Medical emoji are standardized clinical iconography: a controlled-vocabulary, interoperability, and patient-communication problem. Unicode rewards two things: real-world usage (we build that) and a recognized authority affirming a symbol matters and is well-defined. The national informatics body is the ideal source of the second.

July 17

World Emoji Day, the moment to publish letters of support

July 31

Unicode's intake deadline for this cycle

August 1

Our target to have all letters in hand